

photographs by SIPRA UAS

Lakshya...
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Indian Army

ARMY

CAREER ... AND LIFE

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THE SHORTAGE : 11,300

**NUMBER OF NEW OFFICERS
 REQUIRED EVERY YEAR: 2,100**

NUMBER OF SEATS AT IMA: 250

INTAKE THIS YEAR: 86

**NUMBER OF OFFICERS WHO HAVE
 APPLIED FOR PREMATURE
 RETIREMENT SINCE 2004: 2,877**

**OFFICERS WHO HAVE PREMATURELY
 RETIRED SINCE 2004: 1,694**

of steps to make a career in the army attractive for the youth, including time-bound promotions up to the rank of colonel, professional courses for officers who retire at a young age, and more service selection boards for screening and interviewing candidates. Evidently, none of this has worked. Though there is no shortage of soldiers—every year there are 10,000-

**FLOP SHOW: The army's campaign
 has failed to hit the right note**

15,000 applicants for one post—the army is vexed by the declining number of applicants for the posts of officers and a dearth of young captains, majors and colonels. There is a shortage of 11,300 officers or nearly 27 per cent of the strength that was authorised by the government in 1973, but which was never fully realised. "It is probably for the first time anywhere in the world that soldiers are coming in and officers are not," says Major General (retired) Surjit Singh. Part of it can be attributed to the inability of the government to pay higher salaries to attract talent, which finds other, more rewarding avenues that are also relatively risk-free. Today, a management graduate starts at a salary higher than the army chief's Rs 66,000 per month.

The army says it faces a three-pronged challenge: to attract new talent, to keep officers from leaving, and to put an end to the shortage of young officers. To quote an aphorism from the First Pay Commission of 1912, also called the Islington Principle, "The only safe criterion is that the government should pay so much and so much only to its employees as is

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